recommended to delay until the delivery of Kennedy's speech, was never forwarded to Cuba. Instead, Malinovsky, who was clearly worried about the possibility of losing control over the situation on the ground, ordered Pliev to establish a reliable radio connection with Moscow.

A key decision made that morning concerned the Soviet ships heading toward Cuba, and potentially right into the hands of the American navy. "We decided to turn all vessels proceeding to Cuba with weapons back to Soviet ports, while leaving civilian vessels with technical equipment on course until the situation and the details of the quarantine became clear. But not to declare this to the USA immediately," wrote Mikoyan, recalling the morning's discussion. The protocol of the meeting suggests that the decision was approved unanimously, but not all the ships were ordered back. The dry cargo ship *Aleksandrovsk*, with the second load of nuclear warheads, then approaching Cuba, was ordered to remain on course. So were the four Soviet submarines armed with nuclear missiles.[18]

The protocol of the Presidium meeting registers different stages in the process of decision-making on the return of the Soviet ships. First it was agreed to stop new shipments of weapons and order ships that were in the Mediterranean but had not passed Gibraltar to return to the Black Sea. Then they decided to turn back ships that were in the Atlantic but had no chance of reaching Cuba before the imposition of the blockade, with the special exception of the *Aleksandrovsk*. Equally complex was the decision on the nuclear submarines. First they agreed to halt their movement to Cuba and keep them on the "approaches" to the island but later reversed that decision and ordered them to remain on course to Cuba. Mikoyan explained that the idea to keep the submarines away from Cuba was his. He was concerned that their discovery would produce the same kind of reaction in the United States as that caused by the discovery of the missiles.[19]

Khrushchev agreed, and Mikoyan's position was recorded in the protocol. But then Malinovsky was given the floor, and he insisted that the submarines remain on course. He was supported by two or three members of the Presidium, and despite Khrushchev's original backing of Mikoyan's idea, they decided to do as Malinovsky advised. Mikoyan lost the battle once again. First he had been overruled on the issue of missiles, and now on